

THE CONTRARIAN

DEBATE CLUB #9

MOTION TWO OF TWO

THE MOTION

This Club Believes that

Respecting personal autonomy requires society to tolerate self destructive choices

MARK WHERE YOU STAND, NOW AND ON THE WAY OUT

STEP IN

LEAVE THEM TO IT

WHAT THE WORDS MEAN

PERSONAL AUTONOMY

A competent adult's capacity to make informed, voluntary decisions about their own life, by their own values, with nobody coercing them.

SELF DESTRUCTIVE CHOICES

Decisions that risk serious physical, psychological, financial or social harm, mainly to the person making them. Refusing treatment, addiction, gambling, extreme sport, assisted dying.

TOLERATE

To refrain from prohibiting, preventing or punishing a choice you disagree with. Not the same as approving of it: the motion asks whether society should allow, not whether it should applaud.

THE REAL DISAGREEMENT

BOTH SIDES AGREE

Autonomy matters, and society has some duty to prevent serious harm. Neither side denies either, and both accept that some limits on choice are already justified.

THEY SPLIT ON

Is stopping someone from seriously harming themselves a legitimate exercise of social responsibility, or an unjustified exercise of control over their life?

WHERE EACH SIDE STARTS

FOR THE MOTION

An adult who knowingly chooses something that harms mainly themselves should be left to it, however unwise the choice looks from outside.

AGAINST

Autonomy is not absolute. Where the harm is severe or irreversible, or consent is compromised, society may legitimately restrict the choice.

TAKING THE FLOOR

1

Write your question down before you raise your hand. If it does not fit in one sentence, it is not ready.

2

One question at a time, put to the room and not to one person. If you have several, pick the best one.

3

Sharp and specific. The best questions are not opinions in disguise, they are questions the other side has to answer.

4

No personal anecdotes. We are stress-testing arguments, not swapping experiences. If it opens with "I once knew someone who", hold it.

5

A warning at sixty seconds, a hard cutoff at ninety. The buzzer is not a suggestion.

WRITE IT DOWN FIRST

1

2

3

Draft them here while you listen. One sentence each, and if it does not fit on the line it is not ready.

THE ONE YOU WILL ASK

Pick the best of them. One question, put to the room.